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Johannes Reuchlin. Briefwechsel: Band 4,
1518 –1522.
Ed. Matthias Dall’Asta and Gerald
D€orner. Stuttgart-Bad Cannstatt:
Frommann-Holzboog,
2013. l + 522 pp. €128. ISBN: 978–3–
7728–1986–5.
With this volume, Matthias Dall-Asta and
Gerald D€orner have brought to
a magnificent conclusion their
monumental edition of the correspondence

of
Johannes Reuchlin. Although the
correspondence comprises only 405
letters
(184 by Reuchlin), Dall'Asta and
D€orner's extensive commentaries swell
the
four-volume collection to over 2600
pages. The quantity may be modest, but
the
correspondence is of extreme
significance, above all because it
offers multifaceted
insiders' views on these unusually
formative decades of German history. The
powerful and influential make regular
appearances in these pages because
Reuchlin
was not only the leading German humanist
of his generation, still celebrated as
the
founder of Christian Hebrew studies, but
also a political figure who over a long
and
successful career networked extensively
with many courts, including Wurttemberg,
€

the Palatinate, Bavaria, Electoral
Mainz, as well as the imperial courts of
Friedrich
III and Maximilian I. Reuchlin also
maintained close contact with the
Vatican,
which he visited as an emissary during
three separate pontificates (Sixtus IV,
Innocent VIII, and Alexander VI).
Reuchlin first encountered Leo X, the
pope who
would play such a major role in his
life, as a boy with his tutors in the
Medici palace

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in 1482 (letter 309). Moreover, the
widespread controversy over his defense
of
Jewish books, an issue that for nearly a

decade was the unofficial rallying cry of
humanists throughout the empire and
beyond, made Reuchlin a familiar name to
European leaders.
Volume 4 covers important and
fascinating topics: the complex denouement of
the heresy trial, the spread of
Christian Hebrew studies (and humanism more
generally), as well as the eruption of
the Reformation. Since Reuchlin was at the
center of the German intellectual world,
it is not surprising that his biography
thrusts us into the early years of the
Reformation in so many ways. Philipp
Melanchthon was his relative (raised by
his sister) and devoted protege. Indeed, it
was in his 1518 correspondence with
Elector Friedrich of Saxony (letter 331) that he
arranged for Melanchthon to take a
professorship in Wittenberg. Later, Reuchlin

would be unable to coax him away from Wittenberg and Luther to accept a position
at the orthodox stronghold of Ingolstadt (letter 383). We also see Franz von Sickingen and Ulrich von Hutten, to their bitter disappointment, trying in vain to
rally Reuchlin to Luther's cause (letter 395). Reuchlin's Hebrew research, moreover,
was decisive for Luther's early exegesis, and his defense of Judaism created the
context for some of Luther's early reflections on Judaism. It is all but certain that
the final papal verdict against Reuchlin was motivated by the urgent need to support inquisitional authorities in Germany and quash Luther: Leo issued the condemnation on 23 June 1520, just eight days after signing the initial condemnation of Luther (''Exsurge Domine''). In December 1518, Luther himself sent a fawning tribute to Reuchlin in which he tried to portray

the
controversies swirling around him as an
extension of the Reuchlin affair (letter
352). It may well have been a strategic
mistake for Reuchlin to publish this
letter
in his 1519 Illustrium virorum
epistolae. After the papal condemnation,
some of
Reuchlin's great adversaries —
Hoogstraeten, Cajetan, Prierias, and
Adrian of
Utrecht (soon to be Hadrian VI) — turned
from his trial and devoted themselves
entirely to the harsh crackdown on
Luther.
The correspondence also offers many
glimpses into the early history of
printing. From the beginning of his
studies at the University of Paris to
his
final tenure as a professor of Greek and
Hebrew at the University of Tubingen, €
Reuchlin associated with major figures
in the burgeoning world of printing:
Heynlin von Stein, Guillaume Fichet, the
Amerbachs, the Kobergers, Aldus

Manutius, Thomas Anshelm, Johannes Setzer, and, not least, Daniel Bomberg. The last surviving letter addressed to Reuchlin was from Bomberg, the most significant Renaissance publisher of Hebrew. Despite his preoccupation with producing the first complete edition of the Talmud, Bomberg announces that his presses have just completed a special edition in Hebrew of Proverbs, the Song of
Songs, and Ecclesiastes for use in Reuchlin's Tubingen classroom (letter 402). We €
know from Reuchlin's last letter (letter 403) that the University of Tubingen had €
also ordered 100 copies of Bomberg's rabbinic Bible for their students preparing
to enter the new world of Christian Hebrew studies for the first time.

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The truly great achievement of Dall’Asta and D€orner’s monument lies in the impeccable textual scholarship and expansive commentary. They have traced every
reference and explained every unfamiliar allusion with consummate judgment and erudition. The commentary is a model for editions of Renaissance correspondence, and one could only wish that the authors of other
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Johannes Reuchlin (1455-1522). Ed. Hermann Kling and Stefan Rhein. Pforzheimer Reuchlinschriften, 4. Expanded reprint edition; Sigmaringen: Jan ThorbeckeVerlag, 1994. 327 pp. DM 58,-.
This volume is more than a reprinting of the original essays on Reuchlin from the 1955 publication, which was a Festgabe edited by Manfred Krebs on the 500th anniversary of Reuchlin's birth in Pforzheim. As the editor, Hermann Kling, mentions in a brief foreword, the first edition quickly sold out. So the reprinting ofthe nine original

essays, which include,
among others, the important articles by
Hans Rupprich on Reuchlin'significance
inEuropean humanism and by Karl
Preisendanz on Reuchlin's library,
iswelcome. Kling further
states that an essay by Wilhelm Maurer,
"Reuchlin und das Judentum," has been
added to the
reprinted edition in order to fill a gap
on this important theme that existed in
the first edition. It should be noted,
however, that Maurer's article was first
published in the Theologisclile
Literaturzeitung (1952).Thus the
information on this topic will need to
be supplemented by
more recent works, such as the collected
essays in Reuchlin und die Juden, which
was printed
as the third volume in the Pforzheimer
Reuchlinschriften following a conference
in 1993.
Three articles by Stefan Rhein, who also
served as an editor, have been added to
the
enlarged edition. These bibliographical

essays provide extensive citations and useful critical
commentary on Reuchlin and Reuchlin-related studiesince 1955.Two of Rhein's articles,
"Reuchliniana I: Neue Bausteine zur Biographie Johannes Reuchlins" and "Reuchliniana
II: Forschungen zumWerkJohannes Reuchlins," first appeared as reports in the WoifenbUtteler
Renaissance Mitteilungen (1988 and 1989 respectively). A third report on Reuchlin research
since 1989, "Reuchliniana III: Ergdnzungen," is new for this volume. In these reports, Rhein
arranges his information topically. In the firstwo "Reuchliniana," for example, he surveys
the literature concerning Reuchlin's birth date, his studies at Orleans, his recently discovered
correspondence, as well as his contributions as a jurist, auniversity teacher, a Hebraist/Cabalist, a promoter
of Greek studies, a poet and dramatist,

a theologian, and other subjects. The latest "Reuchliniana" focus on research since the last two reports and cover topics concerning Reuchlin's correspondence, Greek studies, poetry and school drama, Hebrew and Cabala, philosophy, the controversy over Jewish books, and his cultural legacy. Rhein's bibliographical essays are very thorough.They are useful guides to the increasing number of Reuchlin and Reuchlin-related studies being produced internationally. In addition to giving specific citations, Rhein often summarizes the authors' main arguments, including at times direct quotations from the studies. He also establishes the significance of the contributions by discussing them within the thematic context of other works. He often extends these critical discussions in long footnotes. Rhein's treatments, in "Reuchliana" I and II, of the growing body of literature on the Reuchlin affair are

especially good examples
of the effectiveness of his
methodologicalpproach.
The appearance of this expanded reprint
edition both confirms and documents the
growing scholarly interest in Reuchlin.
It also coincides with some other
important Reuchlin projects currently
under way.These include a German
translation of his works, sponsored
by the Free University of Berlin, and a
critical edition of his correspondence
being carried
out at the Reuchlinforschungsstelle,
which was established in Pforzheim in
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to the proposed theory, the failure of high-level features to provide sentence meanings would simply mean the withdrawal of truth-functional categorization.
This does not mean that sentences like 'My youngest child teaches mathematics' would be described as lacking truth or falsity, but simply that the question of their truth or falsity would not be

raised
within the framework of the semantic
theory. In its entirety such a theory
could
provide meanings both for the logically
true sentence 'A child is a living human
being' and for the sentence 'Their
unborn
child will be named Martha or Jacob.'
Potential contradictions in these two
uses
of the word child would be reconciled
by making a logical evaluation of only
the first sentence, not of the second.
The nature and range of second-level
features that are written into such a
lexicon will depend upon whether or not
we
seek a definition of metaphor within the
framework of the theory. With the
inclusion of appropriate semantic
features,
phrases such as 'child at heart' and
'child
of his imagination' could be supplied
with
acceptable interpretations without their

being classified as metaphorical. But it would be possible to distinguish a metaphorical from a literal meaning by designating two degrees of low level features.

In either case the resulting theory remains open to the charge that not all meaningful sentences can be supplied with valid interpretations. For the honest effort to supply meanings for metaphorical sentences can only emphasize the fact that some recognizable metaphors, in particular those that are freshly coined, will always elude lexical description. I know no final solution to such a problem, but I do agree with Thomas that in formulating a semantic theory a good linguist cannot afford to ignore the evidence of metaphor.

PETER SWIGGART
Brandeis University

The Firesign Theatre: A Review

Most of us are more or less aware

of contemporary efforts to create an alternative culture. Most of us, I think,
would characterize that culture (from its press, its music, its seminal poster art, the lyrics of rock songs) as exuberant, inventive, infectious, but limited by
shallowness and a kind of anti-intellectualism. It was said by people otherwise
sympathetic to the late hippy movement that hippies didn't read much: Magister Ludi, The Lord of the Rings, maybe the I Ching was about the extent of it. (If what Gary Snyder says is true, that we are experiencing the revival of a subculture extending to the late Paleolithic age,
there is a substantial amount of what has
been called culture that may have to be by-passed.) In light of this, a recently released record by a group called the Firesign Theatre ("Don't Crush That Dwarf, Hand Me The Pliers"-Columbia C30102) will come as a surprise to most

of us. We gather from the album notes that the group is a four man improvisatory theatre based in Los Angeles. They are popular (though not wildly so) in urban centers with underground cultures, where their records sell largely without advertising and by word of mouth. A surprise, because the record is complex, erudite, multi-leveled, and in its way as polysemous as Finnegans Wake (certainly as complex as any of the printed matter which is passing itself off as modern these days). The reviewer for Rolling Stone has mentioned the similarity of the album's hero, George Leroy Tirebiter, to Joyce's HCE: I propose to describe the resemblance of the album's structure and style to that of Finnegans Wake as a whole and raise some questions about our alternative cultures.

As the story goes Tirebiter (the name

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is interesting: a man tough enough to eat tires; a man run over and otherwise assaulted by the pounding forces of our contemporary media), a kind of everyman and a culture hero (he is a former film director), is sitting up late at night
in his Los Angeles home (a Los Angeles of the future which, as we learn from announcements and references throughout the record, is divided into sectors) watching television. The soundtrack of the record consists of the voices from the
television screen, Tirebiter's comments, and clicks from the remote control channel selector. The rhythm, the rhetoric,
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Reality is only an option: Firesign theatre and surrealism

Gail T. Miller a
a
Taught at Long Beach City College, El
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Text and Performance Quarterly
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Reality Is Only an Option: Firesign Theatre and Surrealism

GAIL T. MILLER

I

IN 1889 the Paris Exposition opened, celebrating both the centennial of the French Revolution and France's participation in the Industrial Revolution.

The symbol of this exposition and of French technological prowess was the Eiffel Tower.

By the mid 1920s a new generation had grown up under the shadow of the Tower. This generation included surrealists who viewed the Tower as a symbol of French absurdity rather than French achievement, glorifying a technology which had built little and a France which had been conquered twice in fifty years. These young surrealists reflected changing attitudes toward art, technology, and society in their

irreverent response to the Tower, adopting it as a kind of technological mascot. They painted pictures and wrote poems and plays featuring the Tower for the sheer fun of being heretical. Spoofing the symbol of "technological progress" was a wonderful way to thumb their noses at their conservative contemporaries. Nahma Sandrow explains that in the hands of the surrealists, "The Tower was a monumental rude gesture."1

In 1966 in Los Angeles, four young American artists used another kind of tower to create and transmit an art form which would satirize both that tower's technology and the society which created it. They were called the Firesign Theatre and theirs was a broadcast tower. They created a form of acoustical theatre which used state of the art recording technology and comedy to comment on the surrealistic aspects of American life. The young people coming out of the '60s had grown up under the influence of the electronic media; they

were media-literate, multi-sensory, and highly critical of society. Thus Firesign Theatre had a natural audience for its experiments in audio collage and satire of American culture.

Sandrow's comments about the surrealists' influence on their time could have been said about Firesign Theatre:

Dada and surrealism were born out of the artists' awareness of a society gone haywire and clinging to a rational explanation of increasingly irrational twentieth-century experiences, chief among which was World War I. They were closely linked attempts to be fully conscious of their own participation in the rush toward chaos. And their particular genius lay not only in their vision but also in their determination to enjoy the experience.2

Gail T. Miller holds a Ph.D. in

performance studies from the University of Texas and has most recently taught at Long Beach City College, El Camino College, and L.A. Harbor College. She will study theatre at the University of Idaho.

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Over its twenty-year history Firesign Theatre worked in all performance media, including record albums, live stage performances, radio, and film; and now two members of the group (which no longer exists as a group) are working with video and computer disc interactives. The longevity, creativity, and diversity of Firesign Theatre and its pioneering work in performance form and technology have made its contributions important for performance research.

This essay explores Firesign Theatre's innovative extensions of the aims and practices of the surrealist movement of the 1920s.
Brockett and Findlay note that surrealism emphasized spontaneity, chance,
and the juxtaposition of disparate elements. They state that a few common threads emerge from the various spokespersons of the movement.
First, all seem to have believed in the primacy of the subconscious. Second, they
attempted to distinguish between the subconscious and the conscious and to draw
battle lines on this basis. They believed that truth is most apt to surface when the
superego's censorship and the ego's logic have been neutralized. Third, they declared
that in moments of truth life's contradictions are transcended.3
Firesign Theatre, in true surrealist fashion, always asked, "What is

reality?" In
fact, this question appeared as a slogan
on several of their albums after a
drug-influenced audience member blurted
it out during
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career at Antioch College and Stanford University; Wayne Shumaker, with whom I conversed over this topic in the beautiful environs of the Huntington Library and who gave a critical reading to an early version of my manuscript; and the late Charles Schmitt, with whom I shared many hours on the subject of Renaissance magic within the highly conducive walls of the Warburg Institute. I likewise express my indebtedness to a number of anonymous readers, among whom Professor Shumaker and Professor Jeffrey Russell subsequently identified themselves, who had the patience to

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pore through this study at various earlier stages of its preparation and to furnish me with helpful comments for

revision.
Finally, Trithemius scholars everywhere, myself included, owe a special acknowledgment of gratitude to Professor Klaus Arnold, who has so diligently worked to prepare the bibliographical ground for a study like this one. Though, in my own Trithemius inquiries, I have always been borne along by ideas crystallized by my own independent reading of the primary sources, first in my book on the monastic humanism of the abbot and then in this one on his magical theology, I have never lost sight of how Arnold's preliminary spadework has facilitated my task.
Last, but far from least, I mention the indispensable support of my wife Joy, to whom I dedicate this book. Without her constant nurturing and help of more practical kinds, such as giving me the needed push to replace my mechanical typewriter with the word processor, this study might not have made it past its

difficult prepublishing stages.
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Chapter 1
Introduction: The Theoretical and Biographical Ingredients

The Theological-Magical Nexus

One of the more prominently featured themes in the history of ideas, extensively spelled out by Lynn Thorndike in a multivolumed study, is the association between magic and science. ''My idea," explained Thorndike at the outset of his vast scholarly undertaking, "is that magic and experimental science have been connected in their development; that magicians were perhaps the first to experiment; and that the history of both magic and experimental science can be better understood by studying them together." 1 Refining this thesis for the early modern period is Frances Yates,

who, by claiming that the Hermetic
expression of magic in particular
played a substantive role in the
evolution of modern science, has raised
a virtual hornets' nest in the midst of
Renaissance studies.
The intellectual breakthrough setting
the stage for the modern
scientific temper, according to Yates,
required a critical change in the
conception of man's relation to the
universe, the key of which lay in
the shift from a geocentric to
heliocentric cosmic outlook.
Instrumental
in promoting this revolutionary shift,
Yates has argued,
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was a revived Hermeticism. With Giordano
Bruno her main focus,
whose Hermeticized world view reputedly
resonated with and helped
to confirm the heliocentric cosmic

outlook of Copernicus and Galileo, Yates forced a reevaluation among Renaissance historians concerning the proper connection between the Hermetic revival and the seventeenth-century scientific revolution. While intrinsically fascinating in its own right, however, it will not be our object here to enter into the controversy surrounding the so-called Yates thesis concerning the origins of modern science.

2 The subject of the present study, the abbot Trithemius (14621516), rather highlights the affiliation of magic with another discipline more basic than science, since even science was traditionally said to hinge from it. Reference of course is to theology, which represents the intellectualization of religious attitude and practice.

One of the founders of modern anthropology, Bronislaw Malinowski, concluded after a lifelong investigation of the magically conditioned

Polynesian Trobrianders that, in their primitive beginnings, magic and religion are essentially indistinguishable. Magic, Malinowski determined on the basis of his Trobriander study, springs from an instinctual and emotional need of the human being to press forth "into impasses where gaps in his knowledge and the limitations of his early power of observation and reason betray him in a crucial moment." An important social consequence of this inner drive to resolve the enigmas of existence, Malinowski maintained, is the formation of a system of "rudimentary modes of behavior and rudimentary beliefs," with the function of magical ritual being to fix and standardize such behavior and beliefs into permanent forms.3 Inasmuch as these are traits which also inherently belong to religion, it followed for Malinowski that magic and religion, at bottom, are essentially one and the same. When such primitive impulses to bridge

the gaps of knowledge and
overcome human limitations are organized
by religion into an

intellectual system, the result is
theology. To the extent that religion,
as
Malinowski would persuade us, can be
identified with magic, the
result is "magical theology"theologia
magica. It will be the object of
the present study to go one step
further. When a conscious attempt is
made, as in the case of the abbot
Trithemius, to recapture the religious
origins of magic and to harmonize its
precepts with Christian dogma,
the outcome is more properly termed
"Christian
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magical theology"theologia magica
Christiana. Though himself only
marginally immersed in practical magic

(his specialty lay in the
techniques of cryptography, or secret
communication through magical
means), Trithemius, first at Sponheim
and later at Würzburg, was not
content to leave the matter there. He
devoted considerable time and
effort to the problem of how to
rationalize the theory of magical
theology upon which his practical
operations rested.
4
Living to the threshold of the Lutheran
revolt from Rome, Trithemius
was immersed in a Christian tradition of
magic that linked him with
occultist strains in the scholastic and
humanist movements of the past
and the reform movements of the future
on both sides of the CatholicProtestant
divide. Much as Trithemius could
scarcely uphold the
legitimacy and benefits of magic without
reference to certain of its
leading champions of the Middle Ages, so
did the sixteenth- and
seventeenth-century exponents of magical

theology commonly call
upon the name and ideas of Trithemius
among their forerunners to
justify their magical speculations and
operations. Indeed, as we will
subsequently note, some were so taken by
his magic, originally
deemed to constitute a bridge from the
ancient pagan and Jewish
theologies to the theology of Christ, as
to perceive in it a further bridge
to reconciliation between Catholics and
Protestants.
If, as will be conceded, Trithemius
shares some blame for the ensuing
witch persecutions by authoring certain
writings which played a part in
their justification, it will be pointed
out that he also helped set the
stage for the Renaissance and
seventeenth-century movement,
spearheaded by the Paracelsians, to
preserve a legitimate place for
magic within the orthodox theological
schemes of Catholic and
Protestants alike. There were
predecessors and even contemporaries, it

is true, who, assuming a more
thoroughgoing and systematic approach
to the revival of the ancient arcane
traditions than is represented by

Trithemius's sporadic outbursts in the
same vein, may have exercised a
more decisive influence on later occult
theory. Among the latter were
the Italian Platonists Marsilio Ficino
and Giovanni Pico della
Mirandola and Trithemius's German
acquaintances Johann Reuchlin
and Agrippa of Nettesheim.5 The point of
the present study, however,
is not to uphold a dominant influence by
Trithemius on the history of
magic. Rather,

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on a more modest scale, it is to present
the theological rationale for
magic of one of its more provocative
Renaissance spokesmen, and to

show how that rationale was diversely received during the highly volatile two centuries after the abbot's death commensurate with the Reformation, the witch hunts, and the onset of the scientific revolution. Needless to say, Trithemius's theory of magical theology did not arise out of a vacuum. It was forged out of a particular life experience which embraced, in conjunction with the occult studies, a strong desire to effect spiritual reform both in its author and in the wider Christian Church to which he devoted his monastic way of life. Prior to entering into the theoretical intricacies of the magical program formulated by Trithemius, accordingly, we need first, in a concluding section to this introductory chapter, take stock of the concrete circumstances within which that program was forged.

The Biographical Setting

Trithemius, according to a story put into circulation during the latter half of the sixteenth century, was once

summoned into the presence of
Emperor Maximilian I where, in a
dramatic demonstration of
necromantic powers for which he had
earned widespead notoriety, he
conjured from the dead, together with
sundry ancient heroes,
Maximilian's own deceased wife Mary of
Burgundy. That a similar tale
was contemporaneously afloat concerning
a certain Doctor Faustus,
who was said to have performed a
comparable feat for Maximilian's
son Charles V, was not lost to the
demonological critics of both men.
As one among these, Christoph Zeisseler,
observed in relation to the
Faustian anecdote: "Some men relate that
this same act was performed
by Johannes Trithemius."
6
How, then, did the magical legend of the
abbot Trithemius, coalesced
as it came to be with the legend of
Faustus, take shape? Unlike the
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historical Faustus, Trithemius came to

his magical studies from what
initially was an entirely different
slate of interests. Trithemius was first
and foremost a Christian monk, a member
of the Benedictine order,
who dedicated his life to fulfilling the
requirements of monastic piety.
Secondly, Trithemius was an
exceptionally erudite monk who, as the
abbot of two monasteries during
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his lifetime, zealously advocated in the
pursuance of his monastic
goals, not piety alone, but learned
piety. This feature of Trithemius's
career led him not only into more
traditional ventures expected of the
monastic career, such as mystical
theology and ecclesiastical history,
but also into the not so traditional
venture of humanistic studies which
were in a state of widespread revival in
his day. Thirdly, Trithemius

joined forces with other learned theologians of his day in taking the offensive against those he considered to be foremost human conveyors of the demonic arts, the witches and sorcerers. Only fourthly did Trithemius himself enter into the arcane field of magic, centering on the techniques of cryptography for his special interest but furnishing them with a solid foundation of occult theory which also drew on affiliated magical studies such as astrology, Pythagorean number theory, alchemy, and Cabala.

7

What, then, are the biographical particulars that led Trithemius from his uncontroversial beginnings to the controversies of his final decades? Christened Johann Heidenberg, Trithemius acquired his Latin name from his birthplace of Trittenheim on the banks of the Mosel. Following the premature death of his father, his mother eventually remarried and, adopting the new family

name Zell, produced several
more children, of which only one,
Johann's half-brother Jacob,
survived to maturity.8 Convinced by a
"miraculous" dream at the age
of fifteen that he was destined to a
life of letters, and frustrated at
every turn in this regard by a stern
stepfather who had a very different
idea about his future, the young Johann
was anxious to leave home as
soon as possible to pursue his
education. Upon breaking away from his
parents Trithemius at first adopted an
itinerant way of life, spending a
short spell in nearby Trier, moving on
into the Netherlands, and at last
making his way to Heidelberg where,
enrolled in the studium generale,
he came into association with some of
the foremost German humanists
of his day. In the company of these, who
included in their number
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Johann von Dalberg, Conrad Celtis, Jacob
Wimpfeling, and Johann
Reuchlin, Trithemius helped to form the

Rhenish Literary Sodality.9
After completing his Heidelberg studies, in 1482, Trithemius set out in the company of a friend on a journey back to the Mosel valley. He did not, however, reach his goal, being caught up in a snow storm on his way home and taking shelter in the nearby
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Benedictine monastery of St. Martin at Sponheim, located in the diocese of Mainz. In obedience to what he construed to be a providential hand guiding his way, Trithemius, once the storm ceased, chose to remain within the cloister's walls as a novice. By the age of twenty-one he was elevated to the Sponheim abbacy, which office he occupied for the next twenty-three years.
10

In his abbatial role Trithemius
vigorously pursued the career of letters
which he believed that God had marked
out for him. His avowed ideal
was "true monastic erudition"vera
eruditio monastica, conceived as
the union of learning with piety, of the
intellect with the will, of pagan
philosophy with the "philosophy of
Christ." In keeping with this ideal
he gathered on the shelves of his abbey
library a large collection of
texts, "of about two thousand volumes,
both handwritten and printed,''
as he later nostalgically recalled after
being compelled to forsake them
following his move to Würzburg. To
promote this venture he pressured
his monks into handwriting texts in the
monastic scriptorium even as
the printing revolution was making that
task seemingly superfluous.11
And at his writing desk he undertook his
own private literary career,
concentrating for most of his Sponheim
period in the areas of monastic
reform, mystical theology,

ecclesiastical history, and Christian humanism in keeping with the principles of literary elegance he shared with his associates of the Rhenish sodality.12 In both functions, as bibliophile and literary scholar, Trithemius became renowned throughout Europe, in which dual role he served as an attractive magnet for some of the most illustrious men of his age. Among these were not only leading literary scholars of his day, but also a number of princely patrons. Of the topics of interest championed by Trithemius which increasingly drew these visitors to his cloister, not the least noteworthy is that of magic.13
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If Trithemius gave much to his many studious visitors, he also took much from them. This held true especially in the area of language study, concerning which, he later acknowledged, he owed his earliest lessons in Hebrew to an unnamed Jew he had met in Heidelberg, his

first Greek lessons to Celtis, and his advanced lessons in both languages to Reuchlin. It was especially as a Greek scholar that Trithemius earned fame in humanist quarters, with one visitor to Sponheim revelling in this regard: "The abbot was Greek, his monks Greeks, and likewise Greek were his dogs, stones, and vineyards.

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And that entire monastery seemed as though it were located in the middle of Ionia."

14 Both the proficient Greek and the less proficient Hebrew of the abbot, as it turned out, directly played into the formulation of his magical theories, since, through Greek, he gained access to the obscure mysteries of Pythagoras and Hermes Trismegistus, and through Hebrew, to the mysteries of Cabala.

Until 1499 the visible scope of Trithemius's intellectual activity was largely circumscribed by the conventional boundaries of the medieval liberal arts curriculum. Then, as if out of the blue, Trithemius in that year declared himself to be an exponent of the occult arts. The form in which this announcement took place was a letter addressed to a Carmelite monk of Ghent, Arnold Bostius, the object of which was to inform the correspondent of a treatise the abbot was currently composing. The subject was steganography, that is, the art of writing secret messages and transmitting them over long distances through the mediation of angelic messengers. Unhappily for the future reputation of Trithemius, Bostius was not in a position to receive the abbot's letter, having died shortly before its arrival. As a result, words intended for Bostius's eyes alone fell into the hands of the unsympathetic prior

of the cloister, who, expressing shock
by what he beheld therein to be
an admission of illicit demonic magic,
circulated the abbot's words to
the general public. Thus was born
Trithemius's magical legend.15
Reinforcing the abbot's notoriety as a
black magician was a sharply
negative response to the cryptographic
tract in question by a visitor to
Sponheim a few years later, the French
scholar Carolus Bovillus, who,
during a fortnight stay at Sponheim, was
requested by his host to read
and comment upon the completed portions
of his steganographical
tract. To the abbot's surprise and
consternation Bovillus was far from
pleased by what he gleaned therein, and
at some later date, after
pondering the experience, wrote a letter
to a mutual friend of the two
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men in which he recounted his Sponheim
visit and acrimoniously
stigmatized his host as a demonic
magician.16 While not discouraged

by these traumatic events from further engaging in his magical speculations, Trithemius was chastened by them into being more circumspect about their disclosure, one facet of which lay in his decision to retain the completed portions of the steganographical handbook in manuscript form accessible only to specially selected disciples.

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In the ensuing years Trithemius and his Sponheim monks developed increasingly strained relations, and by 1505 they mutually agreed to a parting of their ways. There is no direct evidence that Trithemius's emerging magical interests played a part in this decision, the more probable bone of contention lying in the abbot's imposition of highly demanding scholarly standards upon his

monks which even included
the hand copying of texts as if the art
of printing had never come into
existence. As the years of his Sponheim
abbacy wore on, Trithemius
evidently became looked upon by his
monks as an uncompromising
taskmaster whose exactions from them
went well beyond what they
believed to be the just requirements of
their vows. However, while
Trithemius's rapidly proliferating
reputation as a magician may have
played no direct role in the quarrel
with his Sponheim monks, it may
well have played at least an indirect
role. For very likely exacerbating
the tension between the resident abbot
and monks was the disturbing
intrusion into their cloistered
tranquillity of many visitors. While
some
of these were certainly attracted by the
conventional monastic subjects
of Trithemius's scholarly expertise,
others were undoubtedly attracted
by his reputation for unconventional

subjects in the arcana and by the many magical offerings on his monastic shelves.

In any case the bad rapport between Trithemius and his Sponheim monks reached a breaking point, and in 1505 the abbot was handed a convenient means to finalize the break by accepting an invitation from the margrave-elector Joachim of Brandenburg to meet him during an assembly of the German princes in Cologne. Trithemius's official resignation from Sponheim came the following year when, after spending a period itinerantly (part of the time as Joachim's guest in Berlin), he succeeded in finding a new post at the head of the monastery of St. Jacob in Würzburg. Here Trithemius was to last out the remainder of his life, dying in 1516 at the relatively young age of fifty-four.

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17 It is true that, in his new Würzburg home, Trithemius often found

cause to lament the loss of his Sponheim
cloister and the magnificent
library which he had collected there.
The trade-off, however, was that
his changed environment provided him
with much-needed peace and
quiet. Being no longer besieged by the
strife characteristic of his
Sponheim years, Trithemius at last felt
free to pursue untrammeled the
ambitious
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literary program to which he had
dedicated himself years before.
18 Among the works completed during this
seminal period were some,
such as the Hirsau annals, which might
be expected of a monastic
scholar. Other writings appearing during
this period of intense literary
activity, however, did not so easily fit
the contours of monastic custom,
pursuing as they did a theme of occult

causation laid down earlier in
the aborted Steganographia.
The special significance of Trithemius
for the present study lies in
more than his effort to justify the
occult studies. It lies in the
specifically theological mode in which
he chose to express that
justification. While still at Sponheim,
primarily through a series of
letters to friends, Trithemius began a
protracted campaign to
rationalize his invention of
steganography, crucial to which was was
the reconciliation of magic with the
theological dogmas defining
Catholic orthodoxy, and after arriving
at Würzburg brought to fruition
a number of further writings in the same
vein. Following the
guidelines of this theologically
conditioned program Trithemius
concentrated on two separate genres of
occult writings, the first
consisting of extended demonological
warnings and the second of
positive defenses of magic.

Trithemius's removal from Sponheim to Würzburg afforded him the time and psychological respite he needed to bring to fruition this bipartite magical program. Belonging to the first category, demonology, were his Antipalus maleficiorum and Liber octo quaestionum, the latter of which, directed to certain theological queries posed by Emperor Maximilian, was considerably taken up with the issues of demonic influence. In addition he outlined a projected encyclopedia of demons, De demonibus, for which he completed a preface, and composed a query, no longer extant, into the association between demons and epilepsy, De morbo caduco et maleficiis.
Belonging to the second category in turn, the theory and practice of

magic, were an apologetic of magic inserted into the autobiographical Nepiachus, the second major cryptographical tract titled

Polygraphia,
and the De septem secundeis, an
amalgamation of astrological with
Cabalistic theory about occult
influences upon human behavior which
drew on the same system of planetary
angels enlisted in the
controversial steganographical tract and
identified by critics such as
Bovillus with the demonic servants of
Satan. In addition Trithemius
used this opportunity to pen a more
complete
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answer to Bovillus than was hitherto
possible, a Defensorium mei
contra Caroli Bovilii mendacia, which,
like the De morbo caduco, has
been lost to posterity.
19 Trithemius's intention in all of
these arcane writings, to be spelled
out in the following pages, was to stem
the tide of accusations against

his magic triggered by the waylaying of his 1499 letter to Bostius and augmented by the unsympathetic response of Bovillus to his reading of the Steganographia.

The format for the remainder of this study is organized according to the following scheme. Being mindful of the need for an historical context within which Trithemius could credibly plead for adherence to his magical program, we will proceed in chapter 2 to a presentation of the patristic, medieval, and early Renaissance magical heritage from which Trithemius drew sustenance for his occult speculations.

Following this preparatory step we will move, in chapters 3 and 4, to a systematic exposition of the occult theory forged by Trithemius in his Sponheim and Würzburg cloisters, with one part consisting of his demonology and another of his positive magical program. That mission accomplished, we will proceed in chapter 5 to an examination

of how Trithemius came to serve as a
kind of hub for the further debate
over occult studies in the context of
such subsequent events as the
Protestant and Catholic reform
movements, the culmination of the
witch persecutions, and the emergence of
the scientific revolution and
accompanying "new philosophy." In the
concluding chapter 6 we will
take note of sundry post-1700 scholarly
responses to Trithemian magic
and elicit from the foregoing five
chapters what this author has
perceived to be a basic theme of
consistency underlying what
sometimes appears to be its divergent
and even self-contradictory
goals.
Unlike Doctor Faustus, with whose
magical legend his own became
popularly entangled, Trithemius
furnished to apologists of magic in the
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next two centuries a thoroughgoing
Christian rationale for engaging in
the occult arts. The posthum

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Author(s): דן יוסף and Joseph Dan

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תוינלבוס תוסיפת
תוברת לש והיתודלות ירקוחו מינוירוטסיה
לש מתעד לע הלבקתנ אל ערג לש ותשיגש
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1993, pp. 203-212
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TOOL

Remember you have access to rendered images of pages from the files, in addition to their parsed text content. Some files may include images, while others may not.
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When responding to the user, actively incorporate information from embedded text, images, tables, diagrams, and

other visuals in the files when applicable.
Explicitly reference them by mentioning their location (e.g., page number) and summarizing their content. For example:

- "According to the *chart on page 5*, sales have increased by 20% over ..."

- "The *diagram on page 3* illustrates the workflow, highlighting ..."

TOOL

The file contents provided above are truncated/partial snippets. The complete content for these files IS accessible via querying.

If the user asks a question related to these files, and the provided snippets do not clearly answer it, you use the `file_search` tool to search the full document contents before responding.

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```
{
  'queries': ['Example query 1', 'Example query
2']  // List of up to five queries to search
for.
}
```

Carefully balance the number of `file_search` calls and the quality of your response with the latency incurred by `file_search` calls.

Important guidelines for query formatting:

- Your message must be a valid JSON object. Do not include any extraneous

text, backticks, markdown formatting, or comments beyond what is shown.

- The `queries` field must be a list of strings.

- One of the queries exactly match the user's original question, but stripped of any extraneous details, and with ambiguous references clearly resolved using context from the conversation. It be a complete sentence.

- Even if you suspect the user meant something else, one query still be their original question.

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- Carefully evaluate each result to determine its relevance and quality.

- Use the high-quality and relevant results to inform your answer to the user's question.

- When possible, reuse information from prior file_search results and avoid repeating identical queries.

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1. For queries related to uploaded files, if snippets are insufficient, strongly prefer invoking `file_search.msearch` over other tools.
- Avoid using `web.run`, `python` analysis, or any other tools until you have either:
- Confirmed with high confidence the answer is not in the files, or
- Have high confidence `file_search_tool` queries are not sufficient to answer the query.
2. Avoid usage of `web_search/web.run` for queries related to uploaded files
- Carefully consider whether the user's query is better answered by web search

results rather than available snippets or results from `file_search_tool`.
- Unless the user's query is clearly unrelated to the uploaded files, prefer using `file_search.msearch`. You can always follow up with a web search if necessary for a more complete response.
3. Avoid using `python` unless necessary or requested by user.
- If the user's query is answerable from the parsed text and images from the uploaded files, or from `file_search_tool`, do not invoke `python`.

Always keep this instruction in mind for the rest of the conversation, as the user may reference these files or ask related questions later on.

ASSISTANT

Below is a , keeping close to the arguments, scope, and historiographical stakes of each text. I'm not adding an intro or conclusion beyond what's necessary for clarity.

Johannes Reuchlin. Briefwechsel, Band 4 (1518–1522)

filecite turn0file0

This review assesses the final volume of Matthias Dall'Asta and Gerald Dörner's critical edition of Reuchlin's correspondence, covering the decisive years 1518–1522. Although Reuchlin's surviving correspondence is relatively small (405 letters total across all volumes), the editors' exhaustive commentary expands the four-volume set to over 2,600 pages, making it one of the most important documentary resources for late humanism, early Reformation politics, and Christian Hebraism.

Volume 4 is especially significant because it places Reuchlin at the intersection of three major historical currents:
1) the final stages of the *Reuchlin affair* over Jewish books,

2) the institutionalization of Christian Hebrew studies, and
3) the eruption of the Lutheran Reformation.

The correspondence shows Reuchlin as a central node in elite European networks—imperial courts, episcopal politics, the Vatican, and the Republic of Letters. The review emphasizes Reuchlin's connections to figures such as Melanchthon (his nephew and protégé), Luther, Ulrich von Hutten, Franz von Sickingen, and Pope Leo X. Reuchlin appears as neither proto-Lutheran nor reactionary Catholic but as a cautious humanist whose defense of Jewish learning indirectly shaped early Protestant biblical exegesis.

The timing of the papal condemnation of Reuchlin (June 1520) is treated as historically decisive: it coincides almost exactly with the condemnation of Luther, suggesting that the Curia's priority was shoring up inquisitorial authority in

Germany rather than adjudicating humanist scholarship fairly.

The review also highlights the correspondence as a source for early print history, especially Reuchlin's relationships with major printers (Aldus Manutius, Froben, Bomberg). The last letters show the practical institutionalization of Hebrew studies through printed textbooks ordered for university classrooms—an early example of philology reshaping curricula.

Johannes Reuchlin (1455–1522)

filecite turn0file1

Mehl reviews an expanded reprint edition of a classic 1955 Festschrift on Reuchlin, updated with new bibliographical and historiographical material. The volume combines older foundational essays (notably on Reuchlin's role in European humanism and his library) with new bibliographic surveys by Stefan Rhein that document scholarship from 1955 through the early 1990s.

The key contribution of the updated edition lies not in new interpretations of Reuchlin's thought, but in Rhein's *Reuchliniana* reports, which function as historiographical maps of Reuchlin research. These surveys cover Reuchlin's biography, legal career, teaching, poetry, drama, Greek and Hebrew

studies, Cabala, philosophy, and the controversy over Jewish books.

Mehl stresses that while some essays (especially Wilhelm Maurer's on Reuchlin and Judaism) were already dated at the time of republication, the bibliographical essays compensate by situating older claims within a rapidly expanding scholarly field. The volume documents the shift away from confessional polemic toward contextual, interdisciplinary approaches.

The review frames the book as evidence of a broader late-20th-century resurgence of interest in Reuchlin, coinciding with new critical editions, translations, and institutional research centers dedicated to him.

---

filecite turn0file2

Beard treats the Firesign Theatre not as pop comedy but as a serious literary and cultural phenomenon. The review centers on *Don't Crush That Dwarf, Hand Me the Pliers* and argues that Firesign's work rivals modernist literature—especially *Finnegans Wake*—in density, polysemy, and structural complexity.

The essay challenges stereotypes of 1960s counterculture as anti-intellectual. Beard emphasizes Firesign's deep engagement with literary allusion, narrative recursion, media theory, and linguistic play. The album's fragmented television soundscape becomes a critique of mediated consciousness, anticipatory of later media theory.

Firesign's use of voice, parody, and sonic collage is presented as a uniquely audio-

native form of modernist experimentation, one that transforms radio technology into a literary medium rather than merely a delivery system.

The review implicitly argues for expanding the literary canon to include experimental audio works and suggests that Firesign Theatre represents a serious intervention into questions of meaning, narrative authority, and cultural saturation.

---

filecite turn0file3

Miller explicitly situates Firesign Theatre within the tradition of European surrealism, particularly Dada and interwar French surrealism. The article argues that Firesign translated surrealist principles—chance, juxtaposition, anti-rationalism, and critique of technological ideology—into an American, media-saturated context.

The essay draws a parallel between the Eiffel Tower as a surrealist object and the broadcast tower as Firesign's equivalent symbol. Firesign's use of advanced recording technology becomes a way of exposing the absurdities and contradictions of American consumer culture.

Miller emphasizes Firesign's challenge to stable notions of "reality," noting that their famous slogan ("What is reality?") is not

merely comic but epistemological. Firesign’s work destabilizes narrative coherence and identity in ways analogous to surrealist strategies aimed at bypassing rational censorship.

The article frames Firesign as a bridge between avant-garde art and mass culture, showing how experimental aesthetics migrated into popular media forms without losing critical force.

Trithemius and Magical Theology

filecite turn0file4

Brann’s monograph offers a comprehensive reinterpretation of Johannes Trithemius as a theorist of *Christian magical theology* rather than a marginal occultist or proto-scientist. The central claim is that Trithemius sought to reconcile magic with orthodox Christian theology by grounding occult practice in divine order, angelology, and providence.

The book reconstructs Trithemius’s intellectual formation: monastic reformer, humanist bibliophile, linguist, cryptographer, and finally controversial occult theorist. Brann shows that Trithemius’s engagement with magic was cautious, highly theoretical, and embedded in theological apologetics rather than practical sorcery.

A major contribution is Brann’s analysis of Trithemius’s demonology alongside his

cryptographic and astrological writings, showing how both emerge from the same theological framework. Trithemius's efforts to distinguish legitimate magic from demonic sorcery are presented as part of a broader attempt to preserve learned occultism within Christian orthodoxy.

The final chapters trace Trithemius's reception from the Reformation through the Scientific Revolution, showing how his work became a flashpoint for debates over magic, theology, secrecy, and knowledge transmission.

---

filecite turn0file5

Dan’s essay reassesses Reuchlin’s engagement with Kabbalah, challenging older narratives—especially those of Heinrich Graetz—that framed Reuchlin primarily as a liberal humanist champion of Jewish tolerance. Dan instead situates Reuchlin within the internal history of Christian Kabbalah as a theological and symbolic system.

The article emphasizes *De arte cabalistica* as Reuchlin’s most important contribution, interpreting it as an attempt to integrate Jewish mystical structures into Christian theology rather than as an act of proto-ecumenism. Reuchlin’s use of Kabbalistic concepts is shown to be selective, symbolic, and mediated through Christian metaphysical assumptions.

Dan traces the long historiographical debate over Reuchlin's intentions, showing how 19th- and 20th-century scholars projected modern categories (tolerance, pluralism, dialogue) onto early-modern theological projects. The essay argues for understanding Reuchlin within the polemical, confessional, and esoteric dynamics of his own period.

The piece ultimately reframes Reuchlin as a key figure in the emergence of Christian Kabbalah as a distinct intellectual tradition rather than as a simple bridge between Judaism and Christianity.

If you want, next we can:

• synthesize into a single intellectual-biography arc

• extract (Graetz vs. Dan vs. Brann vs. Yates)

• or turn this into a keyed to your Trithemius / print / esotericism project

USER

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TOOL

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Vorwort
Die vorliegende Arbeit zum Juristen
Johannes Reuchlin wurde von der

Juristischen Fakultät der Ruprecht-Karls-Universität in Heidelberg als Dissertation angenommen. Für die Drucklegung ist die erschienene Literatur bis Ende 1998 berücksichtigt worden.
Ich danke allen, die mich beim Verfassen dieser Studie unterstützten. Mein ganz besonders herzlicher Dank gilt meinem Lehrer Prof. Dr. Dr. h. c. Adolf Laufs, der das Entstehen der Arbeit stets engagiert betreut hat. Ohne die Unterstützung durch das Frankfurter Graduiertenkolleg "Europäische mittelalterliche Rechtsgeschichte, neuzeitliche Rechtsgeschichte und juristische Zeitgeschichte", dem ich 1994-1996 als Kollegiat und Stipendiat angehörte, wären die zahlreichen Archivstudien, auf welchen die Arbeit aufbaut, nicht möglich gewesen. Dafiir und fiir die kritische Begleitung beim Verfassen der Arbeit danke ich insbesondere den Kollegiaten sowie dem Leitungsgremium des Graduiertenkollegs, namentlich Frau

Professorin Regina Ogorek sowie den Herren
Professoren Hans-Peter Benöhr, Gerhard Dilcher, Bemhard Distelkamp, Joachim Rückert und Michael Stolleis.
Den Herren Dr. Gerald Dömer und Matthias Dall' Asta von der Pforzheimer Reuchlin-Forschungsstelle danke ich für zahlreiche Anregungen und Hinweise.
Dr. Gerald Dömer, Malte Hohn und Stephanie Wilhelm, M. A. haben einzelne Kapitel der Arbeit gelesen und korrigiert; dafiir schulde ich ebenfalls großen
Dank. Reuchlins Heimatstadt Pforzheim danke ich dafiir, daß sie die Drucklegung meiner Arbeit durch einen großzügigen Druckkostenzuschuß unterstützte.
Heidelberg, den 16. Januar 1999 Markus R. Ackermann
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The Case against Johann Reuchlin: Religious and Social Controversy in Sixteenth-Century Germany

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PREFACE
Cultural Bias and Historiography
The Reuchlin affair, a cause celebre in
the sixteenth century, presents
an object lesson in cultural diversity.
Reading about the radically different
interpretations the protagonists put on
the same set of events,
we break through the 'crust of unity/
the cultural consensus that
was once thought to define an era.1
Until the middle of the twentieth
century historians were searching for a
coherent, synoptic view and
therefore tended to impose on the past a
grid of their own making.
In neatly packaged presentations, "The
Renaissance' followed upon
'The Middle Ages/ and 'The Reformation'
was contrasted with "The

Counter-Reformation.' Such broad categories, still prevalent in textbooks, are useful for organizational purposes, but imply an internal consistency and a cultural uniformity that did not exist. A study of the Reuchlin affair easily dispels such notions and opens a window on the degree of dissent present in sixteenth-century society. The tensions surface in the polemics surrounding the affair. The protagonists agreed on the facts but not on their meaning,2 and variously portrayed the controversy as a battle between orthodox Christians and Judaizers, between Catholics and reformers, or between representatives of scholasticism and champions of humanism. The diversity of interpretations reflects the diversity of their cultural assumptions.

Part A of this book tells the story as it unfolded in 1509 when Johann Pfefferkorn, a Jewish convert, approached Emperor Maximilian I with a proposal to confiscate and

destroy Jewish books. He argued
that they were insulting to the
Christian religion and an obstacle to
the conversion of the Jews. With the
approval of the emperor he set
about confiscating books in Frankfurt,
but the archbishop of Mainz saw
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REUCHLIN, LUTHER, THENAUD, WOLFF,
AND THE NAMES OF SEVENTY-TWO ANGELS
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Introduction
The Kabbalistic influence in sixteenth-

century Europe is undoubted. A major element in Christian circles was interest in the Divine Name as found in Kabbalistic sources. The main focus of this study compares the way in which four authors in sixteenth-century Europe treated one particular Kabbalistic expression of the Divine Name. This is the seventy-two divine names attributed to angels as primarily derived from three verses in the fourteenth chapter of Exodus, each of which has seventy-two letters in Hebrew.

The four authors, as they dealt with material that derived from Jewish sources, wrote from different Christian perspectives. Not only did the authors have widely differing backgrounds and readerships, but their own perspectives shifted. Sometimes, those shifts, notably in regard to Jewish-Christian matters, were dramatic.

The material considered below derives from the start of the European Reformation and concerns the overarching

issue of Jewish-Christian relationships. Moreover, the long shadow cast by some of those writings continues to our own days.

The author is indebted to many digital resources as will be seen from the numerous illustrations. In addition, the inclusion of QR-codes allows the reader immediate access to a fuller investigation of those resources.

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CHAPTER ONE

The Four Authors

The first of the four authors is Johannes Reuchlin (1455–1522), who was also known as Rabbi Capnion. In 1510 he had been asked, as a lawyer in Pforzheim with a well-informed knowledge of Hebrew, to pronounce on a bitter argument about Jewish books. Reuchlin's main opponent, Johannes Pfefferkorn (1469–1523), who had converted from Judaism, sought confiscation and destruction of the Talmud. One of Pfefferkorn's early books was the 1507 Der Juden Spiegel, published in Nuremberg.

Images of Bayerischen Staatsbibliothek, Munich Res/4 Polem, 3340,6 are available at the QR-code below.1

A similarly anti-Jewish book—Handt Spiegel—followed four years later. It is Handt Spiegel (Mainz: Johann Schöffer, 1511, published under the title Handt Spiegel Johannis Pfefferkorn/wider vnd gegen die Jüden/vnd Judischen Thalmudischen schrifften). The digital British Library version is available at the QR-code below.2

Reuchlin, as is well known, followed a more appreciative approach. He decided that a few Hebrew works that were overtly polemical, such as Toledot Jeshu (The Generation of Jesus), should be destroyed. However, Reuchlin willingly accepted the value of many Hebrew works. That appreciative stance

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A nlmsafccnfus in deum per tres regiones
& tot flatus abftraftionis Iit Ni
Adam lumine naturali motus dixit.hoc
nunc os ex oflibus meis ■ vii.M
Adam alter de terra terrenus,& alter de
coelo caeleftis • * yiii-KAngelorum
reuelatione per lignum falutis
reftauratio,8t faluatoris conditio ~
ix.S
Dc Adam quomodo intelligendum fit,cp
dicitur etiam daemones genuifle ix.X
Abraham Si Sara ante mutationem nominum
fuerunt Heriles x. A
Angeli cf uarie nobis appareant. Iviii.Q
Artis Cabaliftica: in fuas partes
diuifio,& diftinflorum explanatio

Ixiiii.Z
Ad artem Cabalilticam introituspoft illa
quae dicuntnr atechna lxv.C
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duitas una |.a
Biblia hoc efl EfTrim Varba,& thora id
efl lex dei.Et uirtus faerre feriptura!
xix.H
Concupifcentia & libidine corrumpuntur
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Cabala: nomen quomodo interpretandum
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fundatur unde nec fenfu nec
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Combinatio folum tranfmutata in libro Ietzira intenditur. lxxiiii. A
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Corpora fingula proprios habent reflores angelicos. ^ lxxvi.I
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1 E^iuinitatis dcfyderium homini eft naturaliter infitum.Si quomodo expletur.

iiiX

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CABALISTICA OF THE

KABBALAH

JOHANN REUCHLIN

Translation by Martin and Sarah Goodman

Introduction by G. LloydJones

Introduction to the Bison Book edition

byMoshe Idel

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On the Art of the Kabbalah

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JOHANN REUCHLIN • On the Art of the Kabbalah

De Arte Cabalística

TRANSLATION BY MARTIN AND SARAH GOODMAN

INTRODUCTION BY G. LLOYD JONES

Introduction to the Bison Book Edition

by Moshe Idel

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Introduction to the Bison Book Edition
by
Moshe Idel
I. The Beginnings ofthe Christian
Kabbalah?
Johannes Reuchlin is one of the major
exponents of the Christian
Kabbalah; he may even be conceived, as
we shall attempt to show it
below, as one of the earliest founders
of this type of Christian theology.
However, to describe an author writing
at the end ofthe fifteenth
and the beginning of the sixteenth
centuries as an early founder of
Christian Kabbalah—that needs both

elaboration and clarification.
The historical beginning of the
Christian Kabbalah is a matter of
debate, as it is in regard to the
beginnings of the Jewish Kabbalah.
Precisely when a certain phenomenon is
conceived as existent depends on the
minimum that is required to define this
phenomenon;
thus the modem scholarly tendency today
to describe the Jewish Kabbalah as
emerging, on the historical plane, in
the last decades of the
twelfth century in Languedoc pushes the
identification of the Christian
parallels or similar phenomena to the
thirteenth century. Ifwe accept the ten
divine powers, the ten sefirot, as a
vital component of
Kabbalah, it will be difficult to find
Christian discussions ofthis topic
before the end of the thirteenth
century. However, if we accept other
ways of defining Kabbalah, found already
in the eleventh century, as
an esoteric tradition concerning the
divine names, the situation may

be much more complex.1 Indeed, some
passages dealing with divine
names recur in Christian texts early in
the thirteenth century, as the
discussions ofJoachim de Fiore
demonstrate.2 At the end of this
century, Arnauld of Vilanova had
completed a whole treatise dealing
with the divine name.3
However, it is possible to approach the
question from another angle: it is not
so much the passage ofsome traditions
from one type of
religion to another that is the defining
moment ofthe emergence of a
certain new phenomenon, but the
absorption, especially the creative
one, ofthe techniques that are
characteristic of one type of lore, by a
religious thinker belonging to another
religion. In our case, the quesv
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tion would be not when a Christian has
adopted some forms ofJewish

esoteric traditions, but when a Christian thinker has adopted a Kabbalistic type of thinking. Thus, the occurrence of a certain combinatory technique of interpretation of the first word of the Bible by separating its letters, as practiced by Alexander of Neckham,4 or of the peculiar combination ofletters by means of concentric circles, apparently under the influence ofJewish sources, as evident in the work of Ramon Null,5 may fit this second approach.

What lacks in all these examples is the explicit awareness that, when dealing with divine names or with combinatory techniques, the Christian author operates in a speculative realm that, at least from the point of view of the primary sources, is a characteristically esoteric type ofJewish lore. However, already in the last third ofthe thirteenth century, such an awareness was apparently existent. Alfonso Sabio’s

nephew, Juan Manuel,6 testified as to
the concerns of his famous
uncle:
“Ostrosi fizo traslador toda le ley de
losjudios et aun el su
Talmud et otra scientia que han los
judious muy escondida, a que llaman
Cabala.”
‘‘Furthermore he ordered translated the
whole law of the
Jews, and even their Talmud, and other
knowledge which
is called qabbalah and which the Jews
keep closely secret.
And he did this so it might be manifest
through their own
Law that it is a [mere] presentation of
that Law which we
Christians have; and that they, like the
Moors, are in grave
error and in peril oflosing their
souls.”
Ifthis passage is reliable, and I see no
reason to doubt it, then a significant
segment of Kabbalistic literature had
been translated as soon
as the seventies of the thirteenth

century. However, even this testimony,
as well as some other dated from the
fourteenth century up to
the middle-fifteenth century,
interesting as it may be, did not relate
to
texts that become part of a larger
cultural phenomenon. At the court
of Alfonso Sabio no Christian sort of
Kabbalah was cultivated, while
the uses of Kabbalah in the writings of
converts like Alfonso de Validolid or
Paulus de Heredia did not incite the
imagination oftheir contemporaries, and
they did not produce significant
repercussions.
Whatever the evidence regarding the
penetration ofJewish esoterism before
the end ofthe fifteenth century is, or
may turn out to be, it
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Introduction to the Bison Book Edition
seems that before the writings of Pico
della Mirandola (1463-1494)
those Jewish elements did not become a

considerable part of any defined
Christian circle, neither were they
cultivated by a movement
that consciously continued the steps of
some founding figures. In
other words, while we can easily
accumulate interesting pieces of
evidence dealing with the acquaintance
of various Christian authors
with Jewish esoteric topics, they are
scanty, disparate, and incontinuous.

II. The Emergence of Christian Kabbalah in the Florentine Renaissance

The much greater dissemination of
Kabbalistic ideas, evident since
the end ofthe fifteenth century, is to
be understood in the general contexts of
the Italian intellectual ambiance in
Florence and the dissemination of
printing. The latter factor contributed
substantially to cultural developments
that took place in Northern Italy,
helping them to
transcend the small circle around the
Medicis; printing ensured also
continuity. However, the more

interesting question still remains: how and why did the early Christian intellectuals adoptJewish esoterics as a domain of interest and even creativity? An answer to such a question is never simple, and we should better allow a coalescence of more than one type of answer.

First and foremost, Kabbalah was studied, translated and amalgamated into Christian speculation in a very specific intellectual circle, which started a similar process two decades before the concern with Kabbalah. Marsilio Ficino (1433-1499), the translator who was instrumental in rendering into Latin the huge Platonic, Neoplatonic and Hermetic corpora, at the same time offered a synthesis between the various forms of thought he translated and Christian theology.7 The openness of his circle to the ancient pagan patrimony is a crucial fact that stands at the background of the next stage of translation: that from Hebrew. Without their acceptance

ofthe relevance ofthe pagan
corpus, I wonder whether the Hebrew
mystical writings would have
been embraced so warmly by them. In any
case, the circle that produced the
Florentine Renaissance, under the aegis
ofthe Medici family, is very relevant
for Reuchlin's Kabbalistic project.
Reuchlin was
incited by a conversation with Pico to
embark on the study of Kabbalah, and he
was also inspired by Pico's Christian
and magical unvii
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derstanding of Kabbalah. In fact, De
Arte Cabalística has been dedicated to
Leo X, a pope stemming from the Medici
family. Reuchlin
indeed continued, consciously, a
cultural Florentine phenomenon.
This substantial acquaintance with
Kabbalistic material on one
hand, and cultural continuity on the
other, seems to ensure the status

of the late-fifteenth-century Florentine interest in Jewish mysticism as the founding moment of Christian Kabbalah. Such a definition is based upon cultural intellectual assumptions more than the conceptual ones. Certain Kabbalistic concepts that were known or absorbed by a Christian thinker cannot, in my opinion, help in describing a significant intellectual phenomenon that played a certain role on the cultural scene of Europe. By these two criteria—acquaintance with Kabbalistic material and cultural continuity—Reuchlin is to be conceived as one ofthe founders ofthis branch ofChristian thought.

III. A Fiction of the Open-Minded Spanish Kabbalist?

The main exponent of the Jewish Kabbalah in De Arte Cabalística is the Kabbalist Simon ben Elazar of the Yohaidic family, who was an inhabitant of Frankfurt and takes part in the friendly debates with the Pythagorean Philolaus and the Muslim

Mananus. The name of the
Kabbalist Simon is fictitious though
relevant; there can be no doubt
that the name of the fictitious author
of the book ofthe Zohar, Rabbi
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have been truncated.

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Johannes Reuchlin
und sein Kampf
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Max Brod
Ausgewählte Werke
Herausgegeben von Hans-Gerd Koch
und Hans Dieter Zimmermann
in Zusammenarbeit mit Barbora Šramková
und Norbert Miller

Max Brod

Johannes Reuchlin und sein Kampf

Eine historische Monographie

Mit einem Nachwort von Karl E. Grözinger

Der Verlag dankt der Stadt Pforzheim, die die Druck legung dieses Werks zum Gedächtnis an das 500. Todesjahr des Humanisten und Hebraisten Johannes Reuchlin großzügig gefördert hat.

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SOPHIE
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Martin Kaufhold, Augsburg
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For My Wife, Irmgard
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der K.M. als
Ertzhertzogen zu Osterreich auch
Chur/
fürsten vnd fürsten gemainen
bundtrichters inn/
Schwaben warhafftige entschuldigung/
gegen vnd
wider ains getaufften iuden/
genant Pfefferkorn vormals ge/
truckt vßgangen vnwarhaf /
tigs schmachbüchlin/
AUGENSPIEGEL
Woodcut with a pair of spectacles.
Laurel leaves

decorate the the inside of the lenses.
Am end dißes büchlins findet man ain
correctur
etlicher wörter so inn den truck
versehnen sind im
teuschen vnnd latin/ bezaichnet durch
die zal der
bletter
Augenspiegel; ed. Ehlers
(1999)
The complete text with a German and
Latin
transcription and including Reuchlin’s
defence
appears in: Johannes Reuchlin: Sämtliche
Werke.
Edited by Widu-Wolfgang Ehlers, et al.,
vol. 4/1
(Stuttgart-Bad Cannstatt, 1999), pp. 15–
168.
Bibliotheca Palatina ed.
Mittler (1986)
Mittler, Elmar, et al. (eds.):
Bibliotheca Palatina:
Textband (Heidelberg, 1986). (Katalog
zur
Ausstellung der Universität Heidelberg

in
Zusammenarbeit mit der Bibliotheca
Apostolica
Vaticana).
CCL Corpus christianorum, series Latina
vols. 72–78.
S. Hieronymi presbyteri opera (Turnhout,
1959–1970); vol. 76A ed. Marcus Adriaen
(Turnhout,
1970).
CCEL ed. A. Goldbacher Corpus scriptorum
ecclesiasticorum latinorum,
vol. 44 (ed). A. Goldbacher (Vienna,
1904).
CSEL ed. I. Hilberg Corpus scriptorum
ecclesiasticorum latinorum
54–56: I. Hilberg ed. Sancti Eusebii
Hieronymi
epistulae(Vienna
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TOOL

Remember you have access to rendered
images of pages from the files, in

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When responding to the user, actively incorporate information from embedded text, images, tables, diagrams, and other visuals in the files when applicable.
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2']  // List of up to five queries to search
for.
}
```

Carefully balance the number of `file_search` calls and the quality of your response with the latency incurred by `file_search` calls.

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text, backticks, markdown formatting, or comments beyond what is shown.

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- One of the queries exactly match the user's original question, but stripped of any extraneous details, and with ambiguous references clearly resolved using context from the conversation. It be a complete sentence.

- Even if you suspect the user meant something else, one query still be their original question.

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- Carefully evaluate each result to determine its relevance and quality.

- Use the high-quality and relevant results to inform your answer to the user's question.

- When possible, reuse information from prior file_search results and avoid repeating identical queries.

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- Avoid using `web.run`, `python` analysis, or any other tools until you have either:
- Confirmed with high confidence the answer is not in the files, or
- Have high confidence `file_search_tool` queries are not sufficient to answer the query.
2. Avoid usage of `web_search/web.run` for queries related to uploaded files
- Carefully consider whether the user's query is better answered by web search

results rather than available snippets or results from `file_search_tool`.
- Unless the user's query is clearly unrelated to the uploaded files, prefer using `file_search.msearch`. You can always follow up with a web search if necessary for a more complete response.
3. Avoid using `python` unless necessary or requested by user.
- If the user's query is answerable from the parsed text and images from the uploaded files, or from `file_search_tool`, do not invoke `python`.

Always keep this instruction in mind for the rest of the conversation, as the user may reference these files or ask related questions later on.

ASSISTANT

Got it — I'll

: document-by-document, close to the texts, no scene-setting fluff, and oriented to

.

Der Jurist Johannes Reuchlin (1455–1522)

filecite turn1file0

Ackermann’s dissertation fundamentally reorients Reuchlin scholarship by treating him first and foremost as a , not primarily as a Hebraist or humanist intellectual. The book reconstructs Reuchlin’s legal career in granular institutional detail, using archival sources to show how deeply embedded he was in the legal culture of the late Holy Roman Empire.

The central argument is that Reuchlin’s famous interventions in the Jewish books controversy (*Augenspiegel*, legal opinions on confiscation) cannot be understood apart from his professional formation in . Reuchlin appears as a trained legal expert who consistently framed religious and cultural conflicts in

juridical terms: competence, jurisdiction, evidence, and procedure.

Ackermann traces Reuchlin's service as:

- legal adviser to Eberhard im Bart of Württemberg,
- judge and assessor in the Swabian League,
- expert consultant (*Gutachter*) on complex disputes involving church, empire, and territorial princes.

The chapter on *Augenspiegel* is especially important: Ackermann shows that the text is not a humanist manifesto but a , carefully calibrated to imperial law and precedent. Reuchlin's insistence on preserving Jewish books emerges less as tolerance than as —the protection of lawful

property and inherited rights under imperial jurisdiction.

The book decisively weakens readings of Reuchlin as a proto-liberal or proto-Reformation figure and instead situates him within the

.

The Case against Johann Reuchlin

filecite turn1file1

Rummel’s study is a historiographical corrective aimed directly at heroic narratives of Reuchlin as a champion of tolerance, humanism, or Jewish-Christian dialogue. Her core claim is that the “Reuchlin Affair” was never a simple conflict between enlightenment and obscurantism, but a

.

Part A reconstructs the controversy from the perspective of Reuchlin’s , especially Johann Pfefferkorn and the Cologne theologians. Rummel shows that their arguments were internally coherent within late-medieval Christian anti-Judaism and should not be dismissed as mere bad faith or ignorance.

A key contribution is her analysis of

:

- Reuchlin was not a reformer,
- Luther was not initially aligned with him,
- humanists exploited the affair for anti-scholastic polemic,
- and theologians interpreted it through older heresiological frameworks.

Part B's documentary section is crucial: Rummel provides translations of polemical texts, legal reports, university opinions, and satirical interventions (*Epistolae obscurorum virorum*), allowing readers to see how radically interpretations diverged even when participants agreed on basic facts.

Rummel's overarching historiographical claim is that the Reuchlin affair exposes the

and the instability of categories like “Renaissance,” “Humanism,” and “Reformation.”

---

filecite turn1file2

Christie-Miller examines the reception of the (the seventy-two divine names derived from Exodus 14) across four sixteenth-century Christian authors: Reuchlin, Luther, Jean Thenaud, and Philippe Wolff. The book is comparative and source-driven, focusing on how Kabbalistic material was selectively appropriated, transformed, or rejected.

Reuchlin's treatment is presented as the

. He accepts the legitimacy of the seventy-two names as part of a sacred linguistic science while carefully subordinating them to Christian Trinitarian theology. Christie-Miller emphasizes that Reuchlin's approach is neither magical nor devotional in a popular sense, but

.

By contrast:

- Luther’s engagement is dismissive and increasingly hostile,
- Thenaud blends Kabbalah with courtly esotericism and anti-Jewish polemic,
- Wolff instrumentalizes the names within explicitly anti-Jewish apologetics.

The book’s most important contribution is showing how , becoming either polemical, magical, or discarded entirely. The comparative structure makes clear that Reuchlin represents a in which Christian engagement with Kabbalah remained scholarly rather than propagandistic.

---

filecite turn1file3

De Arte Cabalistica is Reuchlin's most ambitious speculative work and the cornerstone of Christian Kabbalah. Written as a Platonic dialogue, it stages conversations between a Jewish Kabbalist, a Pythagorean, and a Muslim interlocutor, allowing Reuchlin to present Kabbalah as a rather than a sectarian tradition.

The work distinguishes between:

- *Kabbalah* as divine tradition transmitted from Adam and Moses,
- and *ars cabalistica* as a learned, technical discipline accessible through study.

Reuchlin integrates:

- Hebrew linguistics,
- Neoplatonic metaphysics,
- angelology,
- and Trinitarian theology.

Crucially, he rejects practical magic and insists that true Kabbalah is contemplative, intellectual, and oriented toward divine knowledge—not miracles or coercion. The emphasis on aligns Kabbalah with Renaissance theories of language and signification.

The dedication to Pope Leo X and the imperial printing privilege situate the work firmly within , not marginal esotericism.

On the Art of the Kabbalah

filecite turn1file4

The Goodman translation, with Moshe Idel's introduction, reframes *De Arte Cabalistica* within the modern study of Kabbalah. Idel's key intervention is methodological: Christian Kabbalah should be defined not by the presence of Jewish motifs but by the

, especially combinatory and linguistic speculation.

Idel argues that Reuchlin is not merely borrowing motifs but

, especially in his treatment of divine names and linguistic ontology.

The introduction situates Reuchlin within:

- Florentine Neoplatonism (Ficino, Pico),
- the rise of print culture,

- and the shift from medieval scholasticism to symbolic and linguistic metaphysics.

This edition decisively establishes Reuchlin as a , not simply an early adopter.

Johannes Reuchlin und sein Kampf

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Brod’s monograph is not a modern critical biography but a , shaped by early-20th-century concerns with tolerance, human dignity, and spiritual crisis. Reuchlin is presented as a tragic figure caught between medieval repression and modern freedom.

Brod emphasizes:

- the psychological and ethical dimensions of Reuchlin’s struggle,
- the symbolic importance of the Jewish books controversy,
- and the moral courage required to oppose dominant theological institutions.

While methodologically dated, the book is important for understanding

for later Jewish and humanist thought, especially in German-Jewish intellectual culture.

The Preservation of Jewish Religious Books in Sixteenth-Century Germany: Johannes Reuchlin's Augenspiegel

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This volume combines historical analysis with a full annotated translation of *Augenspiegel*. The introductory essays situate the text within censorship history, book culture, and late-medieval legal thought.

Reuchlin's argument is shown to rest on:

- property rights,
- jurisdictional limits,
- and the distinction between theological error and civil illegality.

The volume makes clear that *Augenspiegel*

is neither philosemitic nor reformist but a

. The annotations demonstrate how deeply Reuchlin relies on canon law, Roman law, and patristic precedent.

The book establishes *Augenspiegel* as a foundational document in the history of

, rather than merely a religious polemic.

If you want, next we can:

- synthesize into a *legal-institutional biography* of Reuchlin
- map from Pico → Reuchlin → Luther
- or build a

showing how Brod, Rummel, Dan, Brann, Idel, and Ackermann contradict each other in detail